

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

The Ghaznavids & the Ghurian Invasions - Solved Practice Workbook

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

The Ghaznavids & the Ghurian Invasions	
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BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Hard MCQ 01

Question: Which statement best distinguishes the three political phases?

- A. Mahmud's Ghaznavids held Punjab but did not found the Delhi Sultanate; Muizz al-Din's Ghurids opened wider conquest; post-1206 rulers consolidated an Indian-centred Sultanate.
- B. Aibak ruled independently before Tarain.
- C. The Ghurids were a branch of the Delhi Sultanate created by Iltutmish.
- D. Mahmud and Muizz al-Din were titles of one ruler.

Answer: A - Mahmud's Ghaznavids held Punjab but did not found the Delhi Sultanate; Muizz al-Din's Ghurids opened wider conquest; post-1206 rulers consolidated an Indian-centred Sultanate.

Explanation: Dynasty, objective and chronology must be separated.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 02

Question: What best explains the Samanid connection to Ghaznavid rise?

- A. The Samanids conquered Delhi in the tenth century.
- B. The Samanid military-political order employed Turkic commanders within a Persianate court world.
- C. The Samanids were a Rajput dynasty ruling Lahore.
- D. The Samanids abolished military slavery throughout Central Asia.

Answer: B - The Samanid military-political order employed Turkic commanders within a Persianate court world.

Explanation: Alp-tigin's career grew from this mixed Persianate-Turkic setting.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 03

Question: Which is the safest reading of frontier geography?

- A. Every army used one identical route.
- B. Mountains permanently sealed India from Central Asia.
- C. Routes became militarily effective only when combined with bases, roads, logistics, intelligence and political opportunity.
- D. The Khyber alone made conquest inevitable.

Answer: C - Routes became militarily effective only when combined with bases, roads, logistics, intelligence and political opportunity.

Explanation: Geography enabled and constrained; it did not decide outcomes by itself.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 04

Question: Why is military slavery historically significant here?

- A. It meant all cavalymen were chattel with no political agency.
- B. It was unique to India and unknown in West Asia.
- C. It eliminated succession conflict.
- D. It created trained service commanders dependent on rulers, though such commanders could later found their own powers.

Answer: D - It created trained service commanders dependent on rulers, though such commanders could later found their own powers.

Explanation: Aibak's career shows both dependence and mobility.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 05

Question: Which source is a panegyric court narrative of early Ghaznavid campaigns?

- A. al-Utbi's Kitab al-Yamini.
- B. Prithviraj Raso.
- C. al-Biruni's Kitab al-Hind.
- D. Tabaqat-i Nasiri.

Answer: A - al-Utbi's Kitab al-Yamini.

Explanation: al-Utbi is valuable but shaped by courtly victory rhetoric.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 06

Question: Which source-method statement is correct?

- A. Later chronicles are worthless by definition.
- B. A source's date, genre, patron and distance from the event must be established before using its report.
- C. Inscriptions always provide complete social history.
- D. Contemporary sources need no corroboration.

Answer: B - A source's date, genre, patron and distance from the event must be established before using its report.

Explanation: Source criticism ranks and cross-checks rather than automatically accepting or rejecting.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 07

Question: Why can al-Utbi not serve as the direct account of Somnath 1025?

- A. He wrote only in Sanskrit.
- B. He lived in the sixteenth century.
- C. His narrative closes before that campaign.
- D. He was a Gahadavala court poet.

Answer: C - His narrative closes before that campaign.

Explanation: Chronology is the first source check.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 08

Question: What is the principal limit of Prithviraj Raso for Tarain?

- A. It is a securely dated 1192 inscription.
- B. It is an Arabic Ghaznavid fiscal manual.
- C. It contains no mention of Prithviraj.
- D. It is a layered later literary tradition, not a contemporary battle report.

Answer: D - It is a layered later literary tradition, not a contemporary battle report.

Explanation: It is valuable for memory, not unfiltered chronology.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 09

Question: Which sequence is correct?

- A. Alp-tigin at Ghazni -> Sabuktigin -> Mahmud.
- B. Sabuktigin -> Muizz al-Din -> Alp-tigin.
- C. Mahmud -> Alp-tigin -> Sabuktigin.
- D. Jayapala -> Alp-tigin -> Mahmud.

Answer: A - Alp-tigin at Ghazni -> Sabuktigin -> Mahmud.

Explanation: This is the basic Ghaznavid rise sequence.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 10

Question: What does the Hindu Shahi resistance demonstrate?

- A. All Rajput states fought under one permanent command.
- B. The frontier struggle was prolonged and included offensive coalitions, battles, forts and setbacks.
- C. The Shahis defeated Mahmud permanently in 1001.
- D. The Shahis surrendered without battle.

Answer: B - The frontier struggle was prolonged and included offensive coalitions, battles, forts and setbacks.

Explanation: Jayapala and Anandapala complicate passive-collapse narratives.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 11

Question: How should the 'seventeen invasions' formula be treated?

- A. As a precisely audited contemporary number.
- B. As proof that all campaigns had one motive.
- C. As a conventional count whose total varies with the grouping of operations.
- D. As a count of Ghurid battles after 1175.

Answer: C - As a conventional count whose total varies with the grouping of operations.

Explanation: Use key campaigns and a date range, not false precision.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 12

Question: Which was Mahmud's most durable Indian territorial result?

- A. Permanent annexation of Gujarat.
- B. Direct rule over Bengal.
- C. A Ghaznavid capital at Delhi.
- D. Control in Punjab/Multan and the Lahore-linked frontier sphere.

Answer: D - Control in Punjab/Multan and the Lahore-linked frontier sphere.

Explanation: Operational reach into the plains exceeded administrative reach.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 13

Question: What does the 1018 Mathura-Kanauj campaign best illustrate?

- A. Deep rapid raiding could produce plunder and political shock without lasting annexation.
- B. Ghaznavid settlement of the entire Ganga valley.
- C. The end of all Pratihara and Gahadavala politics.
- D. A Ghurid cavalry defeat.

Answer: A - Deep rapid raiding could produce plunder and political shock without lasting annexation.

Explanation: Raid and rule must be separated.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 14

Question: Which is the best multi-causal thesis on Mahmud?

- A. Only commercial trade explains the raids.
- B. Frontier strategy, political legitimacy, revenue, Central Asian wars and religious rhetoric interacted in changing proportions.
- C. Mahmud had no political interest in Punjab.
- D. Religion was the sole cause of every campaign.

Answer: B - Frontier strategy, political legitimacy, revenue, Central Asian wars and religious rhetoric interacted in changing proportions.

Explanation: A ranked synthesis outperforms single-cause answers.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 15

Question: Why were temples attractive campaign targets in some cases?

- A. Every temple was attacked uniformly.
- B. They were the only places with wealth in India.
- C. They could combine wealth, royal patronage, urban centrality and religious symbolism.
- D. Their destruction automatically transferred land administration.

Answer: C - They could combine wealth, royal patronage, urban centrality and religious symbolism.

Explanation: Temple targeting requires contextual political economy.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 16

Question: What evidence weakens a civilisation-war explanation of Ghaznavid armies?

- A. Ghaznavids avoided all conflict with Muslim rulers.
- B. Punjab had no mixed population.
- C. Mahmud never used religious rhetoric.
- D. Hindu commanders and Jat soldiers served in Ghaznavid forces.

Answer: D - Hindu commanders and Jat soldiers served in Ghaznavid forces.

Explanation: Composite service networks coexisted with coercion and ideology.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 17

Question: Which statement on Somnath sources is correct?

- A. Later Persian, Sanskrit, Jain, epigraphic and modern memory layers must be distinguished from early evidence.
- B. One source silence proves no disruption.
- C. al-Utbi personally witnessed the 1025 raid.
- D. Prithviraj Raso is the primary Somnath source.

Answer: A - Later Persian, Sanskrit, Jain, epigraphic and modern memory layers must be distinguished from early evidence.

Explanation: The event and its memories form different evidentiary layers.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 18

Question: Which statement best describes al-Biruni's method?

- A. A later Rajput heroic poem.
- B. Comparative inquiry using Sanskrit learning across religion, science and social thought.
- C. Court panegyric devoted only to Mahmud's battles.
- D. A tax register of Lahore.

Answer: B - Comparative inquiry using Sanskrit learning across religion, science and social thought.

Explanation: Kitab al-Hind is analytical rather than a conquest chronicle.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 19

Question: What is a major limit of al-Biruni's India account?

- A. He provides a complete village census.
- B. He wrote before contact with India.
- C. Its access is strongest to learned Brahmanical texts and north-western intellectual settings.
- D. He knew no Indian language.

Answer: C - Its access is strongest to learned Brahmanical texts and north-western intellectual settings.

Explanation: Exceptional scholarship still had social and regional blind spots.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 20

Question: What does Persianate most accurately describe?

- A. A Rajput clan system.
- B. A religion separate from Islam.
- C. Only ethnic Persian kings.
- D. A transregional Persian language, literary and administrative culture used by rulers of varied origins.

Answer: D - A transregional Persian language, literary and administrative culture used by rulers of varied origins.

Explanation: Ghaznavid Turkic rulers were major Persianate patrons.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 21

Question: What is the safest interpretation of Lahore's role?

- A. It became a territorial, cultural and logistical bridge between Ghaznavid, Ghurid and early Sultanate phases.
- B. It was founded by Muizz al-Din after 1206.
- C. It was the site of Tarain II.
- D. It remained irrelevant to Indian campaigns.

Answer: A - It became a territorial, cultural and logistical bridge between Ghaznavid, Ghurid and early Sultanate phases.

Explanation: Lahore is the key continuity without dynastic collapse.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 22

Question: Which factor pushed the Ghurids toward India?

- A. A command from the Delhi Sultanate.
- B. A combination of rivalry with Ghaznavids, western pressure and opportunity through Punjab.
- C. The absence of any interests in Ghazni.
- D. A permanent alliance with the Khwarazmians.

Answer: B - A combination of rivalry with Ghaznavids, western pressure and opportunity through Punjab.

Explanation: Constraint and opportunity interacted.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 23

Question: What was distinctive about Ghiyas al-Din and Muizz al-Din?

- A. They fought each other throughout their reigns.
- B. They ruled only after 1206.
- C. Their fraternal partnership divided western and eastern strategic labour.
- D. They were both sons of Mahmud of Ghazni.

Answer: C - Their fraternal partnership divided western and eastern strategic labour.

Explanation: The partnership strengthened Ghurid reach.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 24

Question: Why must early Ghur be studied critically?

- A. It was always a major urban capital equal to Baghdad.
- B. Archaeology proves every chronicle false.
- C. No source mentions Ghur.
- D. Later dynastic sources can caricature its pre-imperial society and religion.

Answer: D - Later dynastic sources can caricature its pre-imperial society and religion.

Explanation: Read Tabaqat against the grain, not literally or dismissively.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 25

Question: Which sequence of Muizz al-Din's early campaigns is correct?

- A. Multan/Uch -> Gujarat setback -> Punjab/Lahore consolidation.
- B. Somnath -> Chandawar -> Lahore.
- C. Tarain II -> Multan -> Gujarat.
- D. Delhi -> Ghazni -> Uch.

Answer: A - Multan/Uch -> Gujarat setback -> Punjab/Lahore consolidation.

Explanation: The sequence reveals strategic adaptation.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 26

Question: What was the chief lesson of the 1178 Gujarat defeat?

- A. Muizz al-Din abandoned India permanently.
- B. Long lines and prepared resistance required a shift toward a Punjab-first strategy.
- C. Ghurid cavalry could never fight in India.
- D. Gujarat was immediately annexed the next year.

Answer: B - Long lines and prepared resistance required a shift toward a Punjab-first strategy.

Explanation: Defeat produced route and base revision.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 27

Question: Which statement best explains Ghurid learning?

- A. He relied on one unchanged desert route.
- B. He never lost a battle.
- C. Muizz al-Din changed routes and preparation after defeats in Gujarat and Tarain I.
- D. He withdrew from Punjab after 1186.

Answer: C - Muizz al-Din changed routes and preparation after defeats in Gujarat and Tarain I.

Explanation: Adaptation, not inherent superiority, is the key.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 28

Question: What does Tarain I prove?

- A. Mounted archery guaranteed Ghurid victory.
- B. Jaichandra led the Ghurid army.
- C. Tarain I founded the Sultanate.
- D. Rajput forces could defeat the Ghurids in open battle, rejecting inevitability.

Answer: D - Rajput forces could defeat the Ghurids in open battle, rejecting inevitability.

Explanation: 1191 is the essential counter-example.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 29

Question: Which tactical description is associated with Tarain II in Satish Chandra?

- A. Mounted archers harassed slower forces through movement and attacks from multiple directions.
- B. The Ghurids won without manoeuvre or reserves.
- C. A purely naval battle.
- D. Only infantry fought on both sides.

Answer: A - Mounted archers harassed slower forces through movement and attacks from multiple directions.

Explanation: Organisation and movement mattered more than one weapon.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 30

Question: Why is the Sanyogita story unsafe as the main explanation for Jaichandra's absence?

- A. No rivalry existed between the dynasties.
- B. It is a later romance; political rivalry is better established than the abduction narrative.
- C. The story appears in al-Utbi before 1020.
- D. Jaichandra fought at Tarain for Muizz al-Din.

Answer: B - It is a later romance; political rivalry is better established than the abduction narrative.

Explanation: Later memory cannot replace contemporary corroboration.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 31

Question: What was the immediate political effect of Tarain II?

- A. It instantly created uniform rule from Gujarat to Bengal.
- B. It restored Ghaznavid power.
- C. It opened the Delhi-Ajmer zone to Ghurid occupation, vassalage and later direct control.
- D. It ended every Chahamana line.

Answer: C - It opened the Delhi-Ajmer zone to Ghurid occupation, vassalage and later direct control.

Explanation: Battlefield victory required political follow-through.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 32

Question: What did Chandawar in 1194 primarily disrupt?

- A. The Seljuk state in Khurasan.
- B. The Ghaznavid court at Ghazni.
- C. The Chola navy.
- D. The Gahadavala coordinating centre under Jaichandra and access to the upper Ganga region.

Answer: D - The Gahadavala coordinating centre under Jaichandra and access to the upper Ganga region.

Explanation: It was a regional dynastic-political turning point.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 33

Question: Why is Chandawar not the end of the conquest story?

- A. Forts, local chiefs, revenue networks and rebellions still had to be managed for decades.
- B. No territory changed hands.
- C. Muizz al-Din immediately retired to Somnath.
- D. The battle occurred before Tarain I.

Answer: A - Forts, local chiefs, revenue networks and rebellions still had to be managed for decades.

Explanation: Conquest and consolidation are distinct.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 34

Question: What was Aibak's central historical role before 1206?

- A. He wrote Kitab al-Hind.
- B. He converted Ghurid victories into bases, garrisons, tribute arrangements and further campaigns.
- C. He was the last Ghaznavid at Lahore.
- D. He commanded Prithviraj at Tarain I.

Answer: B - He converted Ghurid victories into bases, garrisons, tribute arrangements and further campaigns.

Explanation: Delegated continuity mattered.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 35

Question: Which is an example of the limit of distant occupation?

- A. Bayana lay outside India.
- B. Delhi was never occupied.
- C. The Turks could not hold Anhilwara for long after taking it.
- D. Lahore immediately returned to the Ghaznavids after 1186.

Answer: C - The Turks could not hold Anhilwara for long after taking it.

Explanation: Operational success could exceed garrison capacity.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 36

Question: How should Bakhtiyar Khalji's eastern campaigns be framed?

- A. As Mahmud's 1018 campaign.
- B. As the peaceful annexation of all eastern India.
- C. As a naval conquest from Gujarat.
- D. As rapid, delegated and disruptive thrusts that did not instantly produce uniform Bihar-Bengal control.

Answer: D - As rapid, delegated and disruptive thrusts that did not instantly produce uniform Bihar-Bengal control.

Explanation: Speed and surprise require a consolidation caveat.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 37

Question: Which statement on Buddhist monasteries is safest?

- A. Attacks on major Bihar monasteries were severe, but one commander cannot explain the whole long decline of Buddhism.
- B. No monastery was attacked.
- C. Every monastery in India ended in one year.
- D. The attacks created Buddhism in Bengal.

Answer: A - Attacks on major Bihar monasteries were severe, but one commander cannot explain the whole long decline of Buddhism.

Explanation: Long-term institutional change is multi-causal.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 38

Question: Why did the Ghurids use vassal arrangements?

- A. They had no interest in territory.
- B. They reduced immediate administrative burdens and used local authority while garrisons were limited.
- C. Vassalage proves no conquest occurred.
- D. They rejected all tribute.

Answer: B - They reduced immediate administrative burdens and used local authority while garrisons were limited.

Explanation: Accommodation and coercion often alternated.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 39

Question: Which statement best describes the military comparison?

- A. One religious identity determined tactical skill.
- B. Rajputs lacked horses entirely.
- C. The key gap was an interacting system of mobility, command, reserves, finance and logistics, not courage or race.
- D. Turks possessed iron weapons unknown in India.

Answer: C - The key gap was an interacting system of mobility, command, reserves, finance and logistics, not courage or race.

Explanation: Systemic comparison avoids essentialism.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 40

Question: What is the safest statement about elephants?

- A. They automatically caused defeat at every battle.
- B. They were always useless.
- C. Only Ghurids used them.
- D. They could provide shock and stability but required coordinated cavalry and command.

Answer: D - They could provide shock and stability but required coordinated cavalry and command.

Explanation: Combined-arms use determines value.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 41

Question: Why were feudatory contingents a potential command problem?

- A. Separate leadership could hinder unified manoeuvre, reserves and re-concentration.
- B. They were all disloyal in every battle.
- C. They supplied no soldiers.
- D. Turkish armies had no factionalism.

Answer: A - Separate leadership could hinder unified manoeuvre, reserves and re-concentration.

Explanation: A potential organisational cost is not a moral judgement.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 42

Question: Which counter-example is essential against military determinism?

- A. The building of Jam Minaret.
- B. Prithviraj's victory at Tarain I.
- C. Firdausi's poetry.
- D. Mahmud's death in Ghazni.

Answer: B - Prithviraj's victory at Tarain I.

Explanation: The same broad military cultures produced different outcomes.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 43

Question: Why did Ghurids establish wider Gangetic rule than Ghaznavids?

- A. Rajput forces disappeared after 1030.
- B. They had an entirely different religion.
- C. They combined a closer base, territorial objective, delegation and an institutional successor with favourable but contingent opportunities.
- D. Mahmud never controlled Punjab.

Answer: C - They combined a closer base, territorial objective, delegation and an institutional successor with favourable but contingent opportunities.

Explanation: Objective and organisation explain more than identity.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 44

Question: What does post-1206 history add to the comparison?

- A. The Ghaznavids returned under Balban.
- B. No further consolidation was needed.
- C. Muizz al-Din personally ruled Delhi until 1236.
- D. Endurance depended on Aibak and Iltutmish building an Indian-centred state after Ghurid fragmentation.

Answer: D - Endurance depended on Aibak and Iltutmish building an Indian-centred state after Ghurid fragmentation.

Explanation: A battle opening became durable only through later state formation.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 45

Question: Which consequence came earliest and most directly?

- A. Political-military disruption, tribute, loot and new garrisons in selected regions.
- B. Immediate replacement of all village institutions.
- C. Uniform social transformation across India.
- D. The end of Persian culture.

Answer: A - Political-military disruption, tribute, loot and new garrisons in selected regions.

Explanation: Time horizons must be separated.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 46

Question: How should temple destruction be contextualised?

- A. Context proves no destruction occurred.
- B. State rivalry, wealth, symbolism and religious legitimisation can interact without denying violence.
- C. It should be omitted from history.
- D. It always had one identical cause.

Answer: B - State rivalry, wealth, symbolism and religious legitimisation can interact without denying violence.

Explanation: Explanation is neither denial nor monocausal accusation.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 47

Question: What does the UNESCO Jam-Qutb linkage demonstrate?

- A. Architecture proves uniform political control.
- B. Jam and Qutb are the same monument.
- C. Ghurid architectural forms and ornament travelled into early Islamic architecture in India.
- D. Qutb Minar was built by Mahmud in 1025.

Answer: C - Ghurid architectural forms and ornament travelled into early Islamic architecture in India.

Explanation: Influence is not identity.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Hard MCQ 48

Question: Which historiographical synthesis is strongest?

- A. Adopt one communal narrative as total explanation.
- B. Treat all later legends as eyewitness fact.
- C. Ignore chronicles completely.
- D. Combine source criticism, political economy, religious rhetoric, military systems, frontier geography and contingency.

Answer: D - Combine source criticism, political economy, religious rhetoric, military systems, frontier geography and contingency.

Explanation: The problem is multi-source and multi-causal.

Why the distractors fail: Each wrong option collapses chronology, dynasty, source genre, operational outcome or a required qualification.

Remedial MCQ 49

Question: Which ruler is correctly matched?

- A. Mahmud - Ghaznavid ruler, 998-1030.
- B. Aibak - ruler of Ghur in 1163.
- C. Muizz al-Din - founder of Ghaznavid dynasty in 963.
- D. Jayapala - Ghurid commander at Tarain II.

Answer: A - Mahmud - Ghaznavid ruler, 998-1030.

Explanation: Fix the ruler-dynasty distinction first.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 50

Question: Which date pair is correct?

- A. Tarain I 1178; Tarain II 1186.
- B. Tarain I 1191; Tarain II 1192.
- C. Tarain I 1192; Tarain II 1194.
- D. Tarain I 1025; Tarain II 1030.

Answer: B - Tarain I 1191; Tarain II 1192.

Explanation: The sequence is Prithviraj victory then defeat.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 51

Question: Which statement on Somnath is correct?

- A. al-Utbi witnessed the raid.
- B. The raid founded the Delhi Sultanate.
- C. Mahmud raided it in 1025 and did not establish lasting Ghaznavid rule in Gujarat.
- D. The site was never rebuilt or remembered again.

Answer: C - Mahmud raided it in 1025 and did not establish lasting Ghaznavid rule in Gujarat.

Explanation: Retain date, raid and non-annexation.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 52

Question: Which is the correct source match?

- A. Minhaj - eyewitness at Tarain I.
- B. Hasan Nizami - Ghaznavid chronicle ending before 1020.
- C. al-Utbi - Prithviraj's Sanskrit court poem.
- D. al-Biruni - comparative study of India.

Answer: D - al-Biruni - comparative study of India.

Explanation: Know genre and chronology.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 53

Question: What follows from campaign-count variation?

- A. Use a conventional count cautiously and focus on secure campaigns.
- B. Treat seventeen as an official audited total.
- C. Discard every campaign as fictional.
- D. Assume all operations were annexations.

Answer: A - Use a conventional count cautiously and focus on secure campaigns.

Explanation: Uncertain counting is not absence of campaigning.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 54

Question: Which is the best motive answer?

- A. Only plunder mattered in Punjab.
- B. Multiple motives operated, and their weight varied by campaign.
- C. Every temple attack had identical context.
- D. Religion was always irrelevant.

Answer: B - Multiple motives operated, and their weight varied by campaign.

Explanation: Reject single-cause extremes.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 55

Question: Why did the 1178 defeat matter?

- A. It occurred after Chandawar.
- B. It ended Ghurid power permanently.
- C. It pushed Muizz al-Din toward a Punjab-first strategy.
- D. It made Gujarat a Ghurid province.

Answer: C - It pushed Muizz al-Din toward a Punjab-first strategy.

Explanation: Defeat and learning belong together.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 56

Question: Which statement on Tarain II is safest?

- A. Jaichandra's romantic grievance is proven as the sole cause.
- B. Rajputs had no cavalry.
- C. Ghurid victory was inevitable after 1178.
- D. Mobility, command, reserves and preparation interacted; no one weapon explains the outcome.

Answer: D - Mobility, command, reserves and preparation interacted; no one weapon explains the outcome.

Explanation: Use a system explanation.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 57

Question: What does conquest not automatically equal?

- A. Consolidation through garrisons, revenue, alliances and administration.
- B. A chronicle.
- C. A battle.
- D. A campaign route.

Answer: A - Consolidation through garrisons, revenue, alliances and administration.

Explanation: The conceptual distinction is essential.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 58

Question: Which statement on Aibak is correct?

- A. He led Mahmud's Somnath raid.
- B. He managed and extended Ghurid conquests before becoming an independent ruler after 1206.
- C. He wrote Kitab al-Hind.
- D. He was defeated by Prithviraj at Tarain I as Ghurid sovereign.

Answer: B - He managed and extended Ghurid conquests before becoming an independent ruler after 1206.

Explanation: Aibak is commander/manager first, Sultan later.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 59

Question: How should source silence be treated?

- A. As conclusive proof of no event.
- B. As more reliable than archaeology in every case.
- C. As a problem requiring explanation, not proof that an event did not matter.
- D. As permission to invent missing details.

Answer: C - As a problem requiring explanation, not proof that an event did not matter.

Explanation: Absence is evidence only after preservation and genre are assessed.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

Remedial MCQ 60

Question: Which final verdict is most accurate?

- A. Tarain II instantly created rule over all India.
- B. Rajput resistance ended permanently in 1192.
- C. Mahmud and Muizz al-Din had identical objectives.
- D. Ghurid victory opened a new political order, but uniform Sultanate rule emerged only through later consolidation.

Answer: D - Ghurid victory opened a new political order, but uniform Sultanate rule emerged only through later consolidation.

Explanation: Keep the transition staged and contingent.

Remedial target: Correct the common error before attempting the comparison and source-criticism questions again.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ 01 - 2022 Prelims GS-I Q96: Somnath Temple and al-Biruni

Status: Question wording verified through the repository's 2022 routing and matching published paper transcriptions. The official key is unavailable in the local repository; answer is labelled inferred.

Question: The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at Veraval. Which of the following statements are correct regarding Somnath Temple? (1) Somnath Temple is one of the Jyotirlinga shrines. (2) A description of Somnath Temple was given by Al-Biruni. (3) Pran Pratishtha of Somnath Temple (installation of the present day temple) was done by President S. Radhakrishnan.

- A. 1 and 2 only
- B. 2 and 3 only
- C. 1 and 3 only
- D. 1, 2 and 3

Answer: A - 1 and 2 only (INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED; high confidence).

Model solution

- Statement 1 is correct: Somnath is one of the twelve Jyotirlinga shrines.
- Statement 2 is correct: al-Biruni's writing includes a description relevant to Somnath.
- Statement 3 is incorrect: the consecration of the reconstructed present temple in 1951 was performed by President Rajendra Prasad, not S. Radhakrishnan.
- TOPIC LINK: The question tests al-Biruni as a source and modern Somnath memory, not only temple chronology.
- LIMIT: The answer does not validate every later narrative about Mahmud's 1025 raid.

Why this earns marks: It tests each statement independently, gives the key-status warning, links the fact to source criticism and avoids importing contested raid details.

Demand decoding: Treat “The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at...” as a source-and-elimination problem: verify each statement independently, preserve the official wording where available, and separate an inferred key from an official key.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: Identify the tested chronology, site, text, inscription or institution; eliminate each option with one named fact; then state the evidence limit or key-verification status.

How to improve this answer: For “The Prime Minister recently inaugurated the new Circuit House near Somnath Temple at...”, add one explicit sentence explaining why the closest distractor fails on chronology, geography, source class or degree of certainty.

PYQ 02 - 2018 GS-I Mains: Chinese and Arab travellers

Status: Official GS-I question verified in the repository's revised Medieval Topic 01 package; routed here because al-Biruni is a core Topic 02 source.

Question: Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the reconstruction of the history of India. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

- Direct thesis: Chinese and Arab accounts are indispensable external witnesses when their itinerary, genre, language and audience are tested against Indian texts, inscriptions, coins and archaeology.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Xuanzang's seventh-century pilgrimage record describes Harsha's political world, Nalanda and Buddhist geography. It reconstructs institutions and routes, but a Buddhist pilgrim naturally magnified monasteries and sacred centres.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Sulaiman and al-Masudi noticed major Indian powers, ports and commerce connected with the Persian Gulf. They prove India's wide political and trading reputation, though some information circulated through merchants rather than direct observation.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Al-Biruni's Kitab al-Hind used Sanskrit learning to compare religion, astronomy, calendars and social classification. Its analytical precision is exceptional, yet Brahmanical textual access and a north-western setting narrow its social reach.
- Conclusion: These travellers are therefore high-value comparative and corroborative sources, not neutral photographs of all-India conditions.

Why this earns marks: It fulfils 'assess', compares three named source clusters, explains what each reconstructs, supplies a limitation for each and ends with a graded corroboration-based judgement.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Assess the importance of the accounts of the Chinese and Arab travellers in the...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

PYQ 03 - 2020 GS-I Mains: Persian literary sources

Status: Official GS-I question verified in the repository's revised Medieval Topic 01 package; routed here through the Topic 02 and Topic 07 Persian-source banks.

Question: Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model solution

- Direct thesis: Persian works reflect medieval political ideals, conquest, administration, dissent and social worlds, but their 'spirit of the age' becomes representative only through comparison across genres and non-court evidence.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: al-Utbi's ornate Kitab al-Yamini celebrates Sabuktigin and Mahmud and reveals Ghaznavid legitimacy, ghazi language and court ambition. Panegyric, weak Indian geography and its pre-Somnath end limit literal use.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Hasan Nizami's Taj al-Ma'asir and Minhaj-us-Siraj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri record conquest, vassalage, Ghurid genealogy and early Sultanate succession. Court patronage, chronological distance and elite focus shape their selection.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Barani's Tarikh-i Firoz Shahi and normative Fatawa-i Jahandari expose Sultanate politics and aristocratic-orthodox ideals. His didactic hierarchy cannot represent all society.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Abul Fazl's Akbarnama and Ain-i Akbari display Mughal sovereignty and bureaucratic classification, while Badauni preserves conservative dissent. Both are court-centred and partisan in different directions.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Amir Khusrau's panegyric and the Sufi conversations of Fawa'id-ul-Fu'ad widen the archive toward literary encounter and khanqah life, yet remain mediated compositions.
- Conclusion: Persian literature reflects several competing 'spirits' - royal, clerical, administrative, poetic and devotional - rather than one transparent age.

Why this earns marks: It comments rather than lists, spans early Ghaznavid/Ghurid to Sultanate/Mughal genres, links six named evidence clusters to social reach and patronage limits, and gives a qualified verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **comment** requires a direct position on “Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (15...)”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Persian literary sources of medieval India reflect the spirit of the age. Comment. (15...)”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

PYQ search conclusion

- No narrowly battle-specific GS Mains PYQ was located in the bounded repository paper/routing set.
- The package includes one direct Prelims route and two verified Mains source questions with genuine Topic 02 ownership; it does not relabel coaching questions as UPSC PYQs.

Mains 10M-1 - Frontier setting and Ghaznavid rise

Question: Explain how the Central Asian-Afghan political setting enabled the rise of the Ghaznavids on India's north-western frontier. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Ghaznavid power arose from the intersection of Samanid fragmentation, Turkic military service, Persianate court culture and the strategic conversion of Ghazni into a road-linked frontier base.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: The Samanids employed Turkic military slaves and commanders; Alp-tigin established himself at Ghazni in 963. This shows how service office could become dynastic power, though military slaves were never automatically loyal.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Sabuktigin's wars and the c. 990-91 Shahi defeat brought Kabul-Jalalabad into the Ghazni sphere. Strategic depth shifted, but Shahi resistance continued under Jayapala and Anandapala.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Road improvement from Ghazni toward Kabul and Jalalabad supported intelligence, remounts and repeated campaigning. Geography became usable infrastructure, not an inevitable invasion funnel.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Persian language and Samanid-Iranian administrative culture shaped the Turkic court. The result was a Persianate military state, not an ethnically homogeneous army.
- Conclusion: Ghaznavid rise was therefore institutional and logistical as much as martial; the Punjab breach was created through a long frontier struggle rather than one sudden invasion.

Why this earns marks: It answers the enabling setting, uses three precise evidence chains, distinguishes corridor from inevitability and closes with a causal verdict proportional to 10 marks.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Explain how the Central Asian-Afghan political setting enabled the rise of the Ghaznavids...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Explain how the Central Asian-Afghan political setting enabled the rise of the Ghaznavids...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 10M-2 - Mahmud's motives

Question: Mahmud of Ghazni's Indian campaigns cannot be explained by religious zeal alone. Explain. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Religious rhetoric was politically important, but Mahmud's campaigns joined it to frontier security, dynastic legitimacy, revenue extraction and the financing of Central Asian wars.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: al-Utbi's panegyric and Mahmud's image as ghazi/but-shikan legitimised victory and mobilised followers. Court rhetoric, however, cannot reveal the whole strategic calculus.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: The long wars against Jayapala and Anandapala and the annexation of Punjab/Multan secured Ghazni's south-eastern frontier. This territorial aim differs from the non-annexing Mathura-Kanauj and Somnath raids.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Wealth from 1018 and 1025 supported reward networks, Ghazni's display and wars in Khurasan. Loot estimates are rhetorical, but the selection of rich political-temple centres is clear.

- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Hindu officers and Jat soldiers served Ghaznavid armies. This does not erase religious violence; it disproves a simple civilisational bloc model.
- Conclusion: Religion supplied a powerful idiom, while state security, resources and transregional competition structured Mahmud's repeated choices.

Why this earns marks: It preserves religious agency without monocausality, contrasts territorial and raiding objectives and uses four named evidence units in a concise structure.

Demand decoding: The directive **explain** requires a direct position on "Mahmud of Ghazni's Indian campaigns cannot be explained by religious zeal alone. Explain....", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Mahmud of Ghazni's Indian campaigns cannot be explained by religious zeal alone. Explain....", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 10M-3 - Tarain comparison

Question: What explains the reversal between the First and Second Battles of Tarain? (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The reversal came from Ghurid learning, preparation and integrated manoeuvre, combined with the Chahamanas failure to convert the 1191 victory into frontier recovery; it was not predetermined military superiority.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Prithviraj's immediate response to Tabarhinda produced a complete victory in 1191. This proves Rajput battlefield capacity, though the subsequent siege did not expel the Ghurids from Punjab.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Muizz al-Din returned after reorganising disgraced commanders and preparing a renewed army. The narrative of exact numbers is exaggerated, but institutional learning is visible.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Satish Chandra describes mounted archers harassing slower formations from several directions in 1192. Mobility and reserves mattered, though the account is not a modern battlefield survey.
- Claim -> evidence -> significance -> limit: Prithviraj's feudatory coalition had large resources but more fragmented command. Later Sanyogita romance cannot substitute for political analysis.
- Conclusion: Tarain II was a contingent victory created by adaptation, command and strategy after a real Ghurid defeat.

Why this earns marks: It directly compares both battles, uses 1191 as counter-evidence, explains mechanisms and rejects numbers, betrayal and weapon monocausality.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on "What explains the reversal between the First and Second Battles of Tarain? (10 marks, 150....", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 10-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise three named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "What explains the reversal between the First and Second Battles of Tarain? (10 marks, 150....", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 15M-1 - Somnath source criticism and memory

Question: Discuss the Somnath raid through source criticism and explain why its later memory cannot be treated as a simple mirror of 1025. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The 1025 Somnath raid was a major act of plunder, iconoclasm and royal display, but its reconstruction requires separating early reports, later Persian amplification, local records, material phases and modern political memory.
- Event and motive: Somnath joined temple wealth, pilgrimage, port-region commerce and royal symbolism. Mahmud's return without annexing Gujarat supports a high-prestige raid rather than a durable provincial project. This does not reduce the violence to economics alone because ghazi and image-breaking rhetoric carried political-religious value.
- Source chronology: al-Utbi is crucial for Mahmud's earlier ideology but his chronicle ends before Somnath. al-Biruni supplies an early learned description, while later Persian histories often elaborate victory and destruction. Chronological distance and panegyric borrowing require corroboration.
- Local and material evidence: Sanskrit, Jain and epigraphic traditions illuminate rebuilding, patronage and different memory priorities. Their silence or brevity cannot prove indifference, because donation and genealogy records were not trauma chronicles and survive selectively.
- Later memory: Colonial retrieval, nationalist reconstruction and communal politics transformed Somnath into a symbol of civilisational humiliation or recovery. Romila Thapar's multi-voice approach shows that event and retrospective meaning belong to distinct analytical layers.
- Qualification: Exact defender numbers, loot totals, speeches and dramatic image-ransom stories should be excluded unless securely corroborated.
- Conclusion: Somnath is historically important precisely because it combines a recoverable raid with changing political memories; source criticism protects both facts and complexity.

Why this earns marks: It answers both event and memory, ranks five evidence layers, names al-Utbi/al-Biruni/Thapar, states non-annexation and excludes embellished detail.

Demand decoding: The directive **discuss** requires a direct position on "Discuss the Somnath raid through source criticism and explain why its later memory cannot...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Discuss the Somnath raid through source criticism and explain why its later memory cannot...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 15M-2 - Military systems without essentialism

Question: Compare Ghurid and Rajput military systems and assess the causes of Ghurid success without civilisational stereotypes. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Ghurid success reflected an interacting military-fiscal system - mobility, mounted archery, reserves, command, intelligence and bases - while Rajput armies possessed courage, cavalry, elephants and large resources but faced particular coordination problems.
- Mobility and fire: At Tarain II, mounted archers reportedly harassed slower Chahamana formations from several directions. This demonstrates manoeuvre and distance fighting; it does not prove Rajputs lacked bows or horses.
- Command and finance: Mamluk/amirs trained in service and revenue assignments helped rulers maintain concentrated forces. Feudatory Rajput contingents mobilised major resources and local knowledge, but separate

command could impede reserves and rapid re-concentration. Turkish polities also suffered factionalism, so the contrast is relative.

- Combined arms: Elephants supplied shock and stability when coordinated with cavalry. They became vulnerable under harassment or loss of control; they were not inherently obsolete. Iron stirrups and imported horses were known in India, refuting a secret-weapon explanation.
- Logistics and bases: Ghazni-Kabul roads and, later, Lahore/Punjab shortened Ghurid lines. Yet Gujarat 1178, Kashmir 1015 and Bakhtiyar's failed eastern expedition show that supply and terrain could reverse mobile forces.
- Contingency and politics: Tarain I proves Indian forces could win. Prithviraj's political isolation and failure to recover Punjab after 1191 increased risk but should not be converted into timeless 'Rajput disunity.'
- Conclusion: The Ghurid advantage was organisational and situational, not racial, religious or mechanically technological.

Why this earns marks: It covers weapons, command, finance, logistics, politics and counter-evidence, with qualifications in every paragraph and a clear assessed verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **compare** requires a direct position on "Compare Ghurid and Rajput military systems and assess the causes of Ghurid success without...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Compare Ghurid and Rajput military systems and assess the causes of Ghurid success without...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 15M-3 - Conquest versus consolidation

Question: Distinguish conquest from consolidation in the Ghurid expansion, with special reference to Aibak and the eastern campaigns. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Tarain and Chandawar broke major regional coordinating centres, but durable rule required delegated occupation, forts, tribute, local accommodation and repeated suppression; conquest therefore preceded rather than completed consolidation.
- Battlefield opening: Tarain II opened Delhi-Ajmer and Chandawar disrupted Gahadavala power. Their significance was strategic, but neither battle supplied administrators, revenue information or secure countryside control.
- Aibak's mechanism: Muizz al-Din left Qutb al-Din Aibak to occupy Delhi, manage Ajmer rebellions and extend into the doab. Hansi, Samana, Bayana and Gwalior illustrate a fort-and-route strategy. A fort, however, did not guarantee surrounding agrarian obedience.
- Accommodation: Hasan Nizami and coin evidence cited by Satish Chandra suggest initial subordinate arrangements with Tomar/Chahamana authority. Such vassalage economised scarce manpower; rebellion could produce direct occupation. Coin reading and sequence remain debated.
- Distance limit: A Ghurid force took Anhilwara but could not retain it. This proves operational reach exceeded garrison capacity.
- Eastern bound: Bakhtiyar Khalji's Bihar raids and Nadia-Lakhnauti thrust demonstrate surprise and delegated initiative. They damaged major monasteries and displaced the Sena court from Nadia, but Sena successors and regional resistance continued; one attack did not create uniform Bengal rule or single-handedly end Buddhism.
- Conclusion: Consolidation was a negotiated, violent and decades-long process completed only partly under the Ghurids and carried forward by the Delhi Sultanate.

Why this earns marks: It defines both concepts, uses Aibak, forts, vassalage, Anhilwara and Bakhtiyar as evidence, and maintains the Bihar-Bengal source caution.

Demand decoding: The directive **answer** requires a direct position on “Distinguish conquest from consolidation in the Ghurid expansion, with special reference to...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 15-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise five named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Distinguish conquest from consolidation in the Ghurid expansion, with special reference to...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 20M-1 - Why Ghurid rule became wider and more durable

Question: Why did the Ghurids establish wider and more durable rule in the Gangetic plain than the Ghaznavids? Analyse. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The contrast arose from different strategic objectives, inherited bases, timing, delegation and institutional aftermath. It cannot be reduced to the personal ability of Mahmud and Muizz al-Din or to a timeless military superiority.
- Different objectives: Mahmud combined frontier security and Punjab annexation with repeated deep raids whose revenue, prestige and religious legitimisation served a Central Asian empire. Mathura-Kanauj in 1018 and Somnath in 1025 produced reach without Gangetic administration. Muizz al-Din, by contrast, repeatedly sought tribute, forts and territorial succession after Punjab.
- Base and route: Mahmud's defeat of the Shahis and control of Punjab breached the frontier. The Ghurids inherited this achievement, removed Khusrau Malik from Lahore in 1186 and later made Delhi an inland operational base. This shortened lines to the doab.
- Learning and timing: Muizz al-Din lost in Gujarat in 1178 and at Tarain in 1191, then shifted route and preparation. The late-twelfth-century rivalry among Chauhans and Gahadavalas created opportunities, but Tarain I proves the outcome was not inevitable.
- Delegation: Aibak continuously managed Delhi, Ajmer, forts and doab expansion while Muizz al-Din returned west. Bakhtiyar and other commanders extended initiative eastward. This commander network converted royal campaigns into repeated occupation.
- Political mechanisms: Vassal arrangements, tribute, garrisons and use of existing revenue channels economised manpower. The failure to hold Anhilwara and long resistance show their limits.
- Institutional succession: After 1206, the Ghurid empire fragmented, but Aibak and Iltutmish built an Indian-centred Sultanate. No comparable Ghaznavid Gangetic successor had followed Mahmud.
- Qualification: Mahmud was often the more consistently successful general, while Ghurid consolidation remained uneven and took decades.
- Conclusion: Ghaznavid Punjab was the strategic foundation; Ghurid objectives, delegation and post-conquest institutions converted that foundation into a more durable north Indian state.

Why this earns marks: It ranks causes across objective, base, timing, learning, delegation and succession, compares precise campaigns and ends with a graded rather than triumphalist verdict.

Demand decoding: The directive **analyse** requires a direct position on “Why did the Ghurids establish wider and more durable rule in the Gangetic plain than the...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for

a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Why did the Ghurids establish wider and more durable rule in the Gangetic plain than the...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 20M-2 - Consequences and limits

Question: Assess the political, social, economic and cultural consequences of the Ghaznavid-Ghurid incursions and conquests in north India. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: The most immediate consequences were political-military disruption and fiscal transfer; wider social and cultural changes emerged unevenly through Punjab-Lahore settlement, Persianate networks, delegated administration and the later Sultanate.
- Political: Shahi defeat and Ghaznavid Punjab removed strategic depth; Tarain and Chandawar broke Chahamana and Gahadavala coordinating centres. Delhi became a Ghurid base. Yet Rajput successor centres, forts and local chiefs persisted, and consolidation took decades.
- Military: Mobile cavalry, mounted archery, integrated reserves and route-garrison strategy gained importance. Indian forces did not simply disappear; Tarain I and regional resistance show adaptation and continued capacity.
- Economic: Mathura-Kanauj, Somnath, Asni/Banaras and other centres suffered plunder or tribute claims, transferring portable wealth to conquering networks. Punjab also yielded recurring revenue and coin circulation. Effects were regionally unequal; agrarian and commercial life continued beyond attacked nodes.
- Social: New military-service groups, migrants, scholars and merchants interacted with local chiefs, warriors, artisans and revenue intermediaries. Hindu commanders and Jat soldiers in Ghaznavid service reveal composite armies. Chronicle bias, however, leaves non-elite experience obscure.
- Religious institutions: Selected wealthy temples and Bihar monasteries suffered attack for overlapping political, fiscal and ideological reasons. Contextualisation does not deny destruction, while one raid cannot explain all religious change.
- Cultural: Ghazni and Lahore transmitted Persian language, literature and court practice; Firdausi and al-Biruni represent different dimensions of that world. UNESCO's Jam-Qutb comparison illustrates architectural transmission, but Indian craftsmen, materials and motifs transformed the forms.
- State transition: Ghurid victories created an opening, not a completed Sultanate. Post-1206 rulers institutionalised the new order.
- Conclusion: The period was simultaneously coercive, extractive and connective; its consequences were profound but staged, negotiated and regionally varied.

Why this earns marks: It answers every dimension, uses more than eight named evidence clusters, preserves violence and interaction, and repeatedly distinguishes immediate impact from long-term transition.

Demand decoding: The directive **assess** requires a direct position on “Assess the political, social, economic and cultural consequences of the Ghaznavid-Ghurid...”, coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For “Assess the political, social, economic and cultural consequences of the Ghaznavid-Ghurid...”, replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.

Mains 20M-3 - Sources and historiography

Question: Evaluate the sources and historiographical approaches used to reconstruct the Ghaznavid and Ghurid invasions of India. (20 marks, 300 words)

Model answer

- Direct thesis: Reconstruction depends on court chronicles, comparative scholarship, Indic literary-epigraphic traditions and material evidence, each illuminating a different layer and each requiring scrutiny of date, genre, patronage and silence.
- Ghaznavid chronicles: al-Utbi's Kitab al-Yamini offers early campaign and legitimacy language but is ornate panegyric with weak Indian geography and ends before Somnath. Gardizi is more concise but court-linked and derivative in places. Bayhaqi gives unusually rich chancery and fiscal politics, chiefly for Masud's era and through a fragmentary elite archive.
- Al-Biruni: Kitab al-Hind contributes Sanskrit-based comparison in religion, astronomy and society. Its analytical independence is exceptional, yet learned Brahmanical interlocutors and north-western location narrow social reach.
- Ghurid-Delhi sources: Hasan Nizami provides an early conquest narrative shaped by Aibak's court and literary display. Minhaj's Tabaqat-i Nasiri preserves Ghurid genealogy and early Sultanate sequence but was completed c. 1260 under Delhi patronage. Modern UPenn work shows the value of reading it against the grain for Ghur's local society.
- Indic sources: Prithviraja Vijaya and Chahamana inscriptions provide royal self-representation; Prithviraj Raso and later epics reveal memory rather than eyewitness fact. Silence cannot be made proof of no event.
- Material archive: coins linked to negotiated authority, Ghazni and Jam monuments, Qutb inscriptions and fort landscapes can corroborate titles, patronage and occupation. Attribution, reuse, survival and circulation limits remain.
- Historiography: Colonial writing civilisationalised dynastic rupture; nationalist work recovered agency but could romanticise heroes; communal readings absolutised religion; materialist and military studies restored revenue, organisation and logistics; Persianate and memory studies highlight connection and archive construction.
- Conclusion: The strongest account triangulates sources and retains both violence and contingency. It neither repeats court victory rhetoric nor dissolves events into scepticism.

Why this earns marks: It evaluates seven named source clusters and five historiographical approaches, states what each proves and limits, and concludes with a defensible method.

Demand decoding: The directive **evaluate** requires a direct position on "Evaluate the sources and historiographical approaches used to reconstruct the Ghaznavid and...", coverage of every clause, evidence-led analysis and a qualified verdict.

Detailed examiner-grade model status: The solved analysis above is the executable content base. Preserve its named evidence, causal logic, counterpoint and qualification rather than replacing it with a generic narrative.

Executable exam-length answer / compression plan: For a 20-mark answer, open with a two-sentence thesis; organise six to eight named evidence units as claim -> evidence -> inference -> qualification; reserve the final lines for a graded conclusion.

How to improve this answer: For "Evaluate the sources and historiographical approaches used to reconstruct the Ghaznavid and...", replace the weakest generalisation with one additional named site, text, inscription, coin, ruler or scholarly position and state exactly what that evidence cannot prove.